

Your Personal Hearing Care Plan

Category: Live Well Long-Term

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, hearing aid users, adults preparing for follow-up care, family members

Evidence level: Professional, public health, and clinical guideline sources

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Your Personal Hearing Care Plan

Why you need a hearing care plan

Hearing loss is not managed in one appointment. It is usually managed over time. Your hearing needs may change as your hearing changes, your daily routines change, your technology changes, or your listening environments become more demanding.

A personal hearing care plan helps you organize:

- What type of hearing loss you have
- What situations are hardest for you
- What technology you use
- What communication strategies help
- What follow-up care you need
- What medical concerns should be monitored
- What goals matter most in your daily life

The goal is not only to hear more sound. The goal is to communicate more confidently, participate more fully, reduce listening stress, and stay connected to the people and activities that matter to you.

Step 1: Understand your hearing results

Your hearing care plan starts with understanding your hearing test results. Your audiologist may explain:

- Your type of hearing loss
- Your degree of hearing loss
- Whether one ear hears better than the other
- Which pitches are easiest or hardest for you to hear
- Your word recognition scores
- Whether medical referral is recommended
- Whether hearing aids or other technology may help
- How often your hearing should be monitored

You do not need to memorize every detail of your audiogram, but you should understand the main message.

Helpful questions to ask:

- What type of hearing loss do I have?
- Is my hearing loss temporary or permanent?
- Is one ear worse than the other?
- Which sounds am I missing?
- How does this explain my real-life hearing problems?
- How are my word recognition scores?
- Do I need medical follow-up?
- What are my best treatment or support options?

Understanding your results helps you make informed decisions.

Step 2: Identify your real-life listening goals

A hearing test shows how you hear in the clinic. Your hearing goals show how hearing loss affects your real life.

Your goals may include:

- Hearing your spouse or partner more clearly
- Following family conversations
- Understanding grandchildren or children
- Hearing better at work
- Participating in meetings
- Understanding phone calls
- Watching television at a comfortable volume
- Hearing better in restaurants
- Following medical appointments
- Feeling safer with alerts and environmental sounds
- Feeling less tired from listening
- Feeling more confident in social situations

Your audiologist can use these goals to help guide hearing aid settings, assistive technology recommendations, communication strategies, and follow-up care.

A useful goal is specific.

Instead of:

“I want to hear better.”

Try:

“I want to understand my family better at dinner when several people are talking.”

or:

“I want to hear better during work meetings when speakers are across the room.”

Specific goals lead to better planning.

Step 3: Know your hearing technology options

Hearing technology may include hearing aids, assistive listening devices, captioning tools, alerting devices, or implantable hearing options for some people.

Not every adult needs every tool. The best technology depends on your hearing test results, lifestyle, communication needs, physical comfort, technology comfort, budget, and personal goals.

Common options include:

- Prescription hearing aids
- Over-the-counter hearing aids for some adults with perceived mild to moderate hearing loss
- Remote microphones
- TV streamers
- Phone streaming
- Captioned phones
- Smartphone captioning tools
- Video-call captions
- Visual or vibrating alerting devices
- Public assistive listening systems
- Telecoil or hearing loop access
- Cochlear implant evaluation when appropriate

Hearing technology should be matched to the problem you are trying to solve.

For example:

- If phone calls are difficult, you may need Bluetooth streaming, captions, or a captioned phone.
- If television is difficult, you may need captions, a TV streamer, or wireless TV headphones.
- If meetings are difficult, you may need captions, a remote microphone, written notes, or better seating.
- If alarms are difficult, you may need visual or vibrating alerting devices.
- If hearing aids are not enough, your audiologist may discuss additional testing or other hearing technology options.

Step 4: Use communication strategies

Technology helps, but communication strategies are still important. Hearing aids and assistive devices work best when the listening situation is also improved.

Helpful strategies include:

- Face the speaker
- Move closer
- Reduce background noise
- Improve lighting
- Ask people not to speak from another room
- Ask for rephrasing instead of only repetition
- Ask people to speak one at a time
- Repeat back important information
- Use written instructions for important details
- Use captions when available
- Plan ahead for difficult listening situations
- Tell others what helps you hear

Communication should not be the responsibility of only the person with hearing loss. Family, friends, coworkers, caregivers, and healthcare providers can also help by using clear communication habits.

Step 5: Plan your follow-up care

Hearing care usually requires follow-up. This is especially true if you use hearing aids or other hearing technology.

Follow-up appointments may include:

- Reviewing your hearing goals
- Adjusting hearing aid programming
- Checking physical comfort
- Checking hearing aid function
- Reviewing cleaning and maintenance
- Reviewing phone, TV, or Bluetooth use
- Discussing background-noise problems
- Considering remote microphones or accessories
- Updating your hearing care plan
- Repeating hearing testing when needed

Bring specific examples to your follow-up appointments.

Examples:

- “Restaurants are still difficult.”
- “My own voice sounds hollow.”
- “The right hearing aid feels loose.”
- “I hear better at home, but meetings are still hard.”
- “Phone calls are unclear.”
- “I need help connecting to my TV.”
- “I feel tired after wearing the hearing aids all day.”
- “I miss public announcements.”

Specific feedback helps your audiologist make more targeted recommendations.

Step 6: Know when to seek medical care

Some hearing symptoms should be evaluated medically. Hearing aids and communication strategies should not be used to ignore possible medical warning signs.

Contact a healthcare provider, audiologist, or ear, nose, and throat specialist if you notice:

- Sudden hearing loss
- A sudden change in hearing
- Hearing loss in only one ear
- A major difference between ears
- Ear pain
- Ear drainage
- Dizziness or vertigo
- New or one-sided tinnitus
- Ear fullness that does not go away
- Hearing loss after head injury
- A foreign object in the ear
- Earwax blockage that you cannot safely manage
- Hearing that changes quickly

If symptoms are sudden or severe, seek urgent medical guidance.

Step 7: Protect the hearing you have

Hearing protection is part of long-term hearing care. Loud sound exposure can damage hearing. This can happen from very loud sounds over a short time or from repeated loud sound exposure over time.

Common loud sound sources include:

- Concerts
- Power tools
- Firearms
- Motorcycles
- Loud music
- Sirens
- Sporting events
- Certain workplaces
- Yard equipment
- Headphones or earbuds at high volume

Ways to protect your hearing include:

- Use earplugs or earmuffs in loud places
- Use custom hearing protection when appropriate
- Keep headphone volume at a safer level
- Take breaks from loud sound
- Move away from loudspeakers
- Follow workplace hearing protection rules
- Ask your audiologist about hearing protection that fits your needs

If you already have hearing loss, protecting your remaining hearing is especially important.

Step 8: Include family or communication partners

A hearing care plan is often more successful when important communication partners are included. This may include a spouse, partner, adult child, friend, caregiver, or coworker.

Communication partners can help by:

- Learning about your hearing loss
- Facing you when speaking
- Reducing background noise
- Rephrasing instead of saying “never mind”
- Speaking one at a time in groups

- Writing down important details
- Helping track hearing aid concerns
- Attending appointments if you want them there
- Supporting use of hearing technology
- Respecting your communication needs

You should decide who you want involved in your care.

A helpful phrase is:

“I am working on my hearing care plan. It would help me if we used a few communication strategies together.”

Step 9: Track changes over time

Your hearing and communication needs may change. Tracking changes can help you know when to return for care.

Pay attention to:

- Asking for repetition more often
- Turning up the television more than before
- Having more difficulty in noise
- Having more difficulty on the phone
- Avoiding social situations
- Feeling more tired from listening
- Hearing aids not helping as much as before
- New tinnitus
- New dizziness or imbalance
- New ear pain, pressure, or drainage
- Family members noticing more difficulty

If you notice changes, schedule follow-up care. Do not wait until communication becomes very difficult.

Step 10: Review your plan regularly

Your hearing care plan should be reviewed regularly. You may review it:

- After a hearing test
- After a hearing aid fitting
- After follow-up appointments
- When your hearing changes
- When your daily routine changes

- When your work or school demands change
- When you have new communication goals
- When technology becomes difficult to use
- When family members notice new concerns

Your plan should stay practical and personal. It should answer:

- What is my hearing status?
- What are my goals?
- What tools am I using?
- What still feels difficult?
- What support do I need next?
- When should I follow up?

A hearing care plan is not a one-time worksheet. It is a guide you can update over time.

What a strong hearing care plan includes

A strong hearing care plan includes:

- Current hearing test results
- Main listening goals
- Hearing technology plan
- Communication strategy plan
- Follow-up schedule
- Medical referral plan if needed
- Hearing protection plan
- Family or communication partner plan
- Assistive technology plan
- Questions for the audiologist
- A way to track changes over time

This kind of plan helps turn hearing care into daily-life support.

Questions to ask at future appointments

At future appointments, you may ask:

- Has my hearing changed?
- Are my hearing aids still programmed appropriately?

- Are my hearing aids working properly?
- Should my hearing aids be verified or adjusted?
- Are my word recognition scores stable?
- Do I need medical referral?
- Would assistive listening technology help me?
- Would a remote microphone help in noise?
- What can help with phone calls?
- What can help with television?
- What can help with meetings or restaurants?
- How often should I return for hearing testing?
- What symptoms should I report right away?
- Do I need hearing protection?
- Are there newer options that fit my needs?

Writing questions down before the appointment can help you remember what matters most.

A balanced long-term message

Living with hearing loss does not mean giving up important parts of life. It means learning what supports help you communicate, participate, and stay connected.

A balanced hearing care plan recognizes that:

- Hearing loss can affect daily communication.
- Hearing aids and technology can help, but they have limits.
- Communication strategies are important.
- Family and communication partners matter.
- Follow-up care improves outcomes.
- Some symptoms need medical attention.
- Hearing protection matters.
- Emotional well-being matters.
- Your goals should guide the plan.

The goal is not perfect hearing. The goal is better access, better communication, and better participation in daily life.

Key Takeaway

A personal hearing care plan helps you organize your hearing results, listening goals, technology, communication strategies, follow-up care, and long-term support. Hearing care is not a single appointment. It is an ongoing process that should fit your hearing, your life, and your goals.

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